Replacement Theology and the Catholic-Social Movement

Replacement theology, in which the role of Jews and Judaism in salvation history is superceded by Christianity, led to the reinterpretation of the Hebrew Scriptures (Tanakh, or Old Testament) in a speculative fashion, so that historical and political concepts such as Israel, the Exodus, and the Law (Torah) could become "Platonic ideas" permeated by new meanings changing over time.[2] For instance, the term "people of Israel" loses its primary Jewish national significance in order to identify the spiritual community of Christian believers. Similarly, the Exodus is emptied of its centrality in Jewish history to be reinterpreted as a salvific, eschatological time in history. Much of antisemitic discourse originated in replacement theology: the "obsolescence" of Judaism, the sense that the Jewish religion is sterile and legalistic, that the Torah turned the Jews into a particularistic, supremacist, and perfidious nation, with an alleged sense of superiority as the "chosen people."[3]

Modern Catholic-social thought developed in the context of such thinking, arising in the 1880s in France, Italy, and Austria. Conservative artistocrats like Albert de Mun and René de la Tour du Pin in late nineteenth-century France laid down principles and ideological views later adopted by the Catholoic Left, which combined Socialist and Catholic thinking in denouncing "Jewish capitalism" and usury.[4] Although feared by the Church hierarchy, which fought against the atheistic forcesd of radicalism and Marxism, the Catholic-social movement grew rapidly, combining the salvific power of both Christianity and Socialism, directed primarily towards the working masses.[5]

Although suspicious of Socialist ideas, the Church did legitimize Social Catholicism. The 1891 encyclical "Rerum Novarum" of Pope Leo XIII, and the 1931 "Quadragesimo Anno" of Pope Pius IX addressed a range of novel questions about social justice by redefining Catholic "economic, social, and political practice."[6] The movement was profoundly antisemitic, and its antisemitism spread through sermons and teaching by bishops and priests, in the Catholic press, and among political activists, especially in France and Austria.[7]

Three patterns recur in the replacement theology promoted by Palestinian Christian churches.

The first pertains to antisemitism. In the Catholic-Social salvific message directed to the working masses, anti-Judaism played a pivotal role in encouraging political antisemitism, inasmuch as the poor were identified as Christian workers exploited by Jewish capitalist userers. The second pattern shows the evolution of this antisemitism. Clergy and political activists spread

Copyright © 2016. Nebraska. All rights reserved.

Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,